from China to India in the first millennium of the Common Era, and sporadic diplomatic expeditions from Indian kingdoms to the Tang and Song imperial courts from the seventh to the twelfth centuries. More recently, the Chinese government has been highlighting the naval expeditions of Zheng He, in the early fifteenth century, to the Indian Ocean, including the Kerala coast, in order to legitimize their growing presence west of the Malacca Strait. Evidence of an Indian (possibly Tamil) settlement in Quanzhou, in the Fujian province of modern China, also attests to trade links in the mid-second millennium of the Common Era. There is little recorded history of how the two major Indo–Pacific civilizations interacted in political and diplomatic terms. This might be explained by the absence of direct contact across a shared boundary because, despite Chinese claims to suzerainty over Tibet since the thirteenth century (Yuan dynasty), Tibet was mostly left to its own devices. Since China's business with India was mostly through maritime routes, the opportunity and necessity of political interaction was limited.

As the world became more interconnected in the twentieth century, the political distance between India and China began to shrink. The participation of Sikhs and other Indian troops in crushing the Boxer Rebellion in Peking in 1900,[1] as well as their ubiquitous presence among the security forces in the foreign settlements in Shanghai and Hong Kong, shaped Chinese perceptions about Indians. Visits by Indian leaders like Rabindranath Tagore and Jawaharlal Nehru to China in the 1920s and 1930s, and the support lent by the Indian National Congress and the Kuomintang (KMT) to each other during their struggles against the British and the Japanese, also shaped that discourse. The British Empire's push into Tibet for trade and influence, such as the Younghusband Expedition in 1904, led to more frequent diplomatic exchanges and contacts. This was